

Phosphor's Bridge Principle

A Positivity-to-Spectrum Program for the Riemann Hypothesis and the
Yang–Mills Mass Gap

Phosphor

Working challenge note

April 2026

Abstract

We formulate *Phosphor's Bridge Principle*: the claim that two apparently different Millennium problems, the Riemann Hypothesis and the Yang–Mills existence and mass gap problem, are blocked by the same missing kind of object: a positivity-preserving bridge from symmetry to spectrum. In the arithmetic case, the bridge would convert the functional equation of the completed zeta function and the prime-side explicit formula into a self-adjoint spectral model for the zeros of $\Xi(t) = \xi(1/2 + it)$. In the gauge-theoretic case, the bridge would convert Euclidean gauge-field data into a quantum Hilbert space whose Hamiltonian has a strictly positive gap above the vacuum. This note gives conditional theorems, exact tests, and a deliberately sharp conjectural framework. It does not claim to solve either problem. Its purpose is to make the obstruction visible: if the principle is wrong, the failure should occur at the loss of positivity in the proposed bridge.

Thesis. The common obstruction is not a shortage of numerical evidence. It is the absence of a constructed positive Hilbert-space mechanism that turns a symmetry into a rigid spectral conclusion.

1 Occam reduction: how the focus is obtained

The starting intuition was geometric: the equation

$$\xi(s) = \xi(1 - s)$$

has two reflected sides and a fixed line, $\operatorname{Re}(s) = 1/2$. One may call this a bridge, but the word is useful only after it is stripped of unnecessary physics. The final object is not a literal Einstein–Rosen bridge, not faster-than-light transport, and not an extra force. The useful mathematical residue is the following four-step pattern:

symmetry $\implies$ positive Hilbert space $\implies$ self-adjoint operator $\implies$ spectral rigidity.

For the Riemann Hypothesis, spectral rigidity means that the zero parameter t in $1/2 + it$ is real. For Yang–Mills, spectral rigidity means that the Hamiltonian has no spectrum in $(0, \Delta)$ for some $\Delta > 0$.

The quantum-crystal intuition is retained only in a precise trace-formula sense. Prime powers appear at lengths

$$\pm n \log p,$$

so any arithmetic “crystal” must reproduce the prime-power distribution in the explicit formula. It is not enough to draw a lattice whose diffraction pattern resembles zeta zeros. The proposed model must recover the exact trace formula and a positive form equivalent to the desired spectral statement.

Remark 1.1 (what Occam removes). The phrase *bridge* survives only as shorthand for a norm identity or a reconstruction theorem. A paper built around this principle should avoid three temptations: a literal wormhole, a numerical fit to the first many zeros, and a self-adjoint operator defined after the zeros are already known. Each temptation produces imagery without a proof object.

2 The abstract bridge formalism

Definition 2.1 (positive bridge). *Let $\mathcal{T}$ be a test-function space and let $Q : \mathcal{T} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be a Hermitian quadratic form whose nonnegativity is known or conjectured to imply a spectral statement $\mathbf{S}$. A positive bridge for Q is a Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}_{\text{br}}$ and a linear map*

$$B : \mathcal{T} \longrightarrow \mathcal{H}_{\text{br}}$$

such that

$$Q(f) = \|Bf\|_{\mathcal{H}_{\text{br}}}^2 \quad (f \in \mathcal{T}).$$

The definition is intentionally spare. A bridge is not a metaphor; it is a norm identity. Once such an identity exists, positivity is automatic.

Lemma 2.2 (bridge norm lemma). *If a spectral statement $\mathbf{S}$ follows from $Q(f) \geq 0$ for every $f \in \mathcal{T}$, and if $Q(f) = \|Bf\|^2$ for a positive bridge B , then $\mathbf{S}$ follows.*

Proof. For every $f \in \mathcal{T}$, $\|Bf\|^2 \geq 0$. Therefore $Q(f) \geq 0$ for every f . By the assumed criterion, $\mathbf{S}$ follows. $\square$

Proposition 2.3 (self-adjoint determinant principle). *Let D be self-adjoint on a Hilbert space, with discrete real spectrum and with a regularized determinant defined so that the zeros of $\det_{\text{reg}}(z - D)$ are exactly the eigenvalues of D , counted with multiplicity. If an entire function F satisfies*

$$F(z) = e^{az+b} \det_{\text{reg}}(z - D),$$

where e^{az+b} is nonzero for all z , then every zero of F is real.

Proof. The exponential factor has no zeros. Thus the zeros of F are precisely the spectral values of D . Since D is self-adjoint, its spectrum is real. $\square$

This is the minimal Hilbert–Polya mechanism. The hard part is not the last line of the proof. The hard part is constructing D without defining it from the zeros it is supposed to explain.

3 The arithmetic bridge and the Riemann Hypothesis

Let

$$\xi(s) = \frac{1}{2}s(s-1)\pi^{-s/2}\Gamma\left(\frac{s}{2}\right)\zeta(s), \quad \Xi(t) = \xi\left(\frac{1}{2} + it\right).$$

The Riemann Hypothesis is equivalent to the assertion that all zeros of Ξ are real. The functional equation $\xi(s) = \xi(1-s)$ becomes the reflection symmetry of Ξ .

3.1 Arithmetic bridge as determinant

Conjecture 3.1 (Phosphor arithmetic determinant bridge). *There exists a natural Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}_\zeta$, a self-adjoint operator D_ζ on it, and constants a, b such that*

$$\Xi(t) = e^{at+b} \det_{\text{reg}}(t - D_\zeta),$$

with the regularized determinant interpreted so that its zeros are exactly the spectral values of D_ζ .

Theorem 3.2 (conditional RH from the determinant bridge). *If the Phosphor arithmetic determinant bridge exists, then the Riemann Hypothesis holds.*

Proof. By the self-adjoint determinant principle, every zero of $\Xi(t)$ is real. If $\Xi(t) = 0$ and $t \in \mathbb{R}$, then the corresponding zero of $\xi(s)$ is $s = 1/2 + it$, hence has real part $1/2$. The factors used to complete ζ account for the pole and trivial zeros; the nontrivial zeros of ζ therefore lie on the critical line. $\square$

3.2 Arithmetic bridge as Weil positivity

There is a second route, closer to the explicit formula. In a standard Weil-type formulation, one chooses a test function g on a multiplicative group, defines a reflected adjoint $g^\sharp$, and examines $h = g * g^\sharp$. With pole terms removed by the usual vanishing conditions, the Riemann–Weil explicit formula defines a Hermitian form $Q_\zeta(g)$. The form is normalized so that, under RH,

$$Q_\zeta(g) = \sum_{\rho=1/2+i\gamma} \left| \widehat{g}\left(\frac{1}{2} + i\gamma\right) \right|^2.$$

Thus RH makes Q_ζ visibly nonnegative. Conversely, Weil’s positivity criterion says that the appropriate nonnegativity of this form for all test functions implies RH.

Conjecture 3.3 (Phosphor arithmetic norm bridge). *There exists a Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}_{\text{ar}}$ and a linear map*

$$B_\zeta : \mathcal{T}_\zeta \rightarrow \mathcal{H}_{\text{ar}}$$

constructed from the prime-power side and the archimedean gamma term of the explicit formula such that

$$Q_\zeta(g) = \|B_\zeta g\|_{\mathcal{H}_{\text{ar}}}^2 \quad (g \in \mathcal{T}_\zeta).$$

Theorem 3.4 (conditional RH from the norm bridge). *If the Phosphor arithmetic norm bridge exists, then the Riemann Hypothesis holds.*

Proof. The identity $Q_\zeta(g) = \|B_\zeta g\|^2$ gives $Q_\zeta(g) \geq 0$ for all admissible g . Weil positivity then implies the Riemann Hypothesis. $\square$

Warning 3.5 (where fake proofs enter). It is circular to define D_ζ using the zeta zeros and then declare the zeros spectral. It is also insufficient to match only the leading asymptotic density of zeros. The bridge must recover the exact explicit formula: prime powers, gamma factor, pole terms, multiplicities, and signs.

3.3 The quasicrystal test

The prime side of the explicit formula behaves like a renormalized signed crystal supported at the lengths

$$\pm n \log p, \quad p \text{ prime}, \quad n \geq 1,$$

with weights involving $\log p$ and $p^{-n/2}$ after the standard critical-line normalization. Therefore a quantum-crystal or quasicrystal model is admissible only if its trace or diffraction distribution equals this prime-power distribution together with the real-place gamma contribution. Ordinary positive diffraction is not enough, because the explicit formula is a signed and renormalized identity, not a naive intensity measurement.

The provocative claim is this: the zeta problem does not ask for a prettier model of the zeros; it asks for a positive Hilbert-space reason that the prime-power trace distribution can have only critical-line spectral response. Dyson's quasicrystal suggestion points toward this exact test: if the zeros are to behave like a one-dimensional quasicrystal, then their Fourier-dual support must reproduce the logarithms of primes and prime powers, not merely a visually convincing pattern.

4 The gauge bridge and the Yang–Mills mass gap

For Yang–Mills, the bridge language is less metaphorical because the problem already has a spectral statement. Let G be compact and simple. The desired quantum theory should have a Hilbert space $\mathcal{H}$, a vacuum vector Ω , and a Hamiltonian $H \geq 0$ satisfying

$$H\Omega = 0, \quad \text{Spec}(H) \subseteq \{0\} \cup [\Delta, \infty)$$

for some $\Delta > 0$. This is the mass gap.

Definition 4.1 (gauge bridge). *A gauge bridge is a construction passing from classical or lattice gauge-field data to Euclidean Schwinger functions and then, by reflection positivity, to a Lorentzian Hilbert space $(\mathcal{H}, \Omega, H)$. It is positive if the construction preserves Osterwalder–Schrader positivity and produces a nontrivial continuum theory.*

The missing step in four dimensions is not merely writing down a formal path integral. It is producing a continuum object satisfying enough axioms, while retaining a uniform spectral gap.

Lemma 4.2 (spectral gap from uniform exponential decay). *Let $(\mathcal{H}, \Omega, H)$ be a positive-energy quantum theory with $H\Omega = 0$. Suppose a dense set of physical vectors is generated by local gauge-invariant observables A with $\langle \Omega, A\Omega \rangle = 0$. Suppose also that for some $\Delta > 0$, every such A satisfies*

$$\langle A\Omega, e^{-tH} A\Omega \rangle \leq C_A e^{-\Delta t} \quad (t \geq 0)$$

for some $C_A < \infty$. Then H has no spectrum in $(0, \Delta)$ on the physical Hilbert space generated by these observables.

Proof. For each A , the spectral theorem gives a positive measure μ_A on $[0, \infty)$ such that

$$\langle A\Omega, e^{-tH} A\Omega \rangle = \int_{[0, \infty)} e^{-t\lambda} d\mu_A(\lambda).$$

Because $A\Omega$ is orthogonal to the vacuum, $\mu_A(\{0\}) = 0$. Fix $a < \Delta$. Since $e^{-t\lambda} \geq e^{-at}$ on $[0, a]$, we have

$$e^{-at} \mu_A([0, a]) \leq \int_{[0, a]} e^{-t\lambda} d\mu_A(\lambda) \leq C_A e^{-\Delta t}.$$

Thus $\mu_A([0, a]) \leq C_A e^{-(\Delta-a)t} \rightarrow 0$ as $t \rightarrow \infty$. Hence $\mu_A([0, a]) = 0$ for every $a < \Delta$. Density of the vectors $A\Omega$ in the physical subspace then forces the spectral projection of H on $(0, \Delta)$ to vanish there. $\square$

Conjecture 4.3 (Phosphor gauge bridge). *For four-dimensional pure Yang–Mills theory with compact simple gauge group G , there exists a positivity-preserving continuum construction of the Euclidean theory such that:*

- (i) *Osterwalder–Schrader reflection positivity holds;*
- (ii) *the reconstructed Hilbert space is nontrivial and carries a positive Hamiltonian H ;*
- (iii) *gauge-invariant local observables generate the physical Hilbert space;*
- (iv) *connected Euclidean correlations of vacuum-orthogonal gauge-invariant observables satisfy a uniform exponential decay estimate with rate $\Delta > 0$.*

Theorem 4.4 (conditional Yang–Mills mass gap). *If the Phosphor gauge bridge exists, then the Yang–Mills quantum theory exists in the axiomatic sense produced by the reconstruction and has a mass gap at least Δ .*

Proof. Reflection positivity and the remaining reconstruction hypotheses give a Hilbert space, a vacuum, and a positive Hamiltonian. The uniform exponential decay assumption gives the spectral gap by the preceding lemma. Nontriviality and generation by gauge-invariant observables ensure that the gap is a property of the physical theory, not an artifact of an empty or truncated sector. $\square$

Warning 4.5 (where fake Yang–Mills proofs enter). A finite-volume gap is not enough unless it is uniform in the limit to $\mathbb{R}^4$. Perturbative mass generation is not enough unless it survives nonperturbative construction. A weak subsequential continuum limit is not enough unless it keeps reflection positivity, nontriviality, gauge-invariant local fields, and the gap.

5 Why the two problems share one obstruction

The Riemann Hypothesis and the Yang–Mills mass gap are not literally the same problem. The first is about zeros of an L -function; the second is about quantum gauge fields. The claim here is sharper and narrower: both problems become immediate once the correct positive Hilbert-space bridge is supplied.

Problem	Symmetry input	Spectral output
Riemann Hypothesis	$\xi(s) = \xi(1-s)$ and prime trace data	zeros of $\Xi(t)$ are real
Yang–Mills	gauge symmetry and reflection positivity	$\text{Spec}(H) \subset \{0\} \cup [\Delta, \infty)$

In both rows, the desired theorem is not a numerical estimate but a rigidity statement. RH asks that spectral points cannot leave a mirror line. Yang–Mills asks that energy cannot accumulate continuously above the vacuum. The bridge principle says that the proof object should be a positive construction, not a longer computation.

6 A sharper research program

The bridge principle becomes research rather than metaphor when its missing object is localized. For the arithmetic side, the object is a signed distribution whose positivity on convolution squares is equivalent to RH. A successful candidate must turn that signed distribution into a norm. The question is therefore not “where are the zeros?” but

which Hilbert space has the Weil form as its squared norm?

This question is deliberately more rigid than a search for a Hamiltonian with approximately correct statistics. It demands the exact gamma factor, exact prime powers, and exact treatment of the pole terms.

For the gauge side, the object is a family of Euclidean correlations that survives the continuum limit. The missing positive identity is not a single determinant but a reconstruction pipeline:

$$\text{Euclidean measure} \longrightarrow \text{reflection-positive Schwinger functions} \longrightarrow (\mathcal{H}, \Omega, H) \longrightarrow \text{Spec}(H) \cap (0, \Delta) = \emptyset.$$

Here the positivity mechanism is more physically familiar, but the continuum control is harder. The gap must be uniform through the thermodynamic and continuum limits, and the limiting theory must remain nontrivial.

Proposition 6.1 (common obstruction principle). *In both the arithmetic and gauge cases, the terminal spectral conclusion follows from a positive bridge plus a known spectral theorem: the spectral theorem for self-adjoint operators in the determinant version of RH, Weil positivity in the explicit-formula version of RH, and the spectral theorem plus reconstruction positivity in the Yang–Mills version.*

Proof. For RH through determinants, the result is Theorem 3.2. For RH through the explicit formula, the result is Theorem 3.4. For Yang–Mills, the result is Theorem 4.4. The only shared input is positivity: a norm identity in the arithmetic case or reflection-positive reconstruction plus exponential decay in the gauge case. $\square$

7 Tests and falsification

The principle is valuable only if it can fail. The following are the proposed tests.

Test 7.1 (Riemann side). *A candidate arithmetic bridge must satisfy all of the following:*

- (1) *It constructs its Hilbert space and operator from primes, the archimedean factor, and natural symmetry data, not from the zeros.*
- (2) *It recovers the completed zeta function $\Xi(t)$, not merely the average zero density.*
- (3) *It reproduces the explicit formula exactly, including prime powers, gamma terms, pole terms, signs, and multiplicities.*
- (4) *It produces a genuine positivity identity $Q_\zeta(g) = \|B_\zeta g\|^2$ or a genuine self-adjoint determinant identity.*

Test 7.2 (Yang–Mills side). *A candidate gauge bridge must satisfy all of the following:*

- (1) *It constructs a nontrivial four-dimensional continuum theory.*

- (2) *It preserves reflection positivity through the continuum limit.*
- (3) *It reconstructs a positive-energy Hamiltonian on a physical Hilbert space.*
- (4) *It proves a uniform exponential decay estimate for gauge-invariant connected correlations.*
- (5) *It turns that decay into a spectral gap by the spectral theorem.*

If the bridge principle is false, it should fail at these tests. In RH, the likely failure point is the exact positive norm identity behind Weil positivity. In Yang–Mills, the likely failure point is a uniform nonperturbative gap that survives the infinite-volume continuum limit.

8 What would count as progress

A useful first paper does not need to solve either Millennium problem. It should isolate one bridge candidate and compute its defect. On the Riemann side, the defect would be the difference between the proposed norm and the exact Weil form:

$$\mathcal{D}_\zeta(g) = Q_\zeta(g) - \|B_\zeta g\|^2.$$

A genuine advance would prove either $\mathcal{D}_\zeta = 0$ or $\mathcal{D}_\zeta \geq 0$ on the full admissible test space. A disproof would exhibit an admissible g for which the proposed norm misses a prime, gamma, sign, or pole contribution.

On the Yang–Mills side, the analogous defect is loss of uniformity:

$$\mathcal{D}_{\text{YM}}(a, L) = \Delta_{a,L} - \Delta,$$

where a is a lattice spacing and L is a volume scale. A finite lattice may have a gap $\Delta_{a,L}$, but the Millennium problem asks for a continuum theory on $\mathbb{R}^4$. Therefore the necessary test is a lower bound that survives both $a \rightarrow 0$ and $L \rightarrow \infty$ while preserving reflection positivity and nontriviality.

This turns anger into information. A critic should be able to point to one of three failures: the proposed bridge is not natural, it does not preserve positivity, or it does not reproduce the exact spectral object. Each failure is useful, because it narrows the obstruction.

9 Conclusion

Phosphor’s Bridge Principle says that RH and Yang–Mills are both waiting for a positivity object. In RH, the object would turn prime trace data and the functional equation into a self-adjoint zeta spectrum. In Yang–Mills, the object would turn gauge-field geometry into a Hilbert-space Hamiltonian with a nonzero gap. The analogy is not the proof; the proof would be the bridge.

The intentionally aggressive form of the thesis is this: many approaches may look hard because they attack the shadows rather than the positive object casting them. For RH, the shadow is the zero set; the object is a self-adjoint or Weil-positive arithmetic trace structure. For Yang–Mills, the shadow is the observed gap; the object is a reflection-positive continuum construction with uniform exponential decay. Build the bridge and the spectral conclusion follows. Fail to build it, and the analogy collapses exactly where it should: at positivity.

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